Wk 3 summative Assessment : Social Media Blog Post

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AMPT/430: Social Media and Human Interaction

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01/27/2025

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In today's digital age, social media platforms have become a cornerstone of how individuals gather and share information. While these platforms provide significant value, they also create a rift with things like misinformation, clickbait, and hidden agendas. The way individuals interact with this information, influenced by personal biases, can have profound effects on both personal and professional relationships.

Social media has become a tool for staying informed about hobbies, interests, and trending topics. Many people, including myself, use social media to discover insights shared by investigative reporters, health professionals, beatify and fashion insights and other people that have similar interests as you. For instance, my interest in optimizing health has led me to follow accounts run by neuroscientists, women's health professionals and psychologists who not only share useful information but also include supporting resources and literature to expand my knowledge on the topics. That said, all of our feeds our curated into our own personal echo chambers, from our favorite fashion to our home décor, to the people who trust to give us information.

Unfortunately, social media is often used to spread misinformation, which can lead to significant consequences. One relevant example occurred during the early stage of the COVID019 pandemic. Social media became a breeding ground for stated opinions being disguised as fact. Misinformation about the virus's origin, vaccine safety, and untested remedies blanketed our feeds. This "infodemic" – as labeled by the World Health Organization – undermined public health campaigns and are said to have exacerbated the outbreak. Disinformation not only created chaos and confusion but also fractured relationships (Gale, 2023). Families broke apart, lifelong friendships ended, and workplaces became contentious. People's personal and professional lives were deeply affected by pandemic-related narratives, with some leaving their careers and industries all together due to the influence of misleading information online.

On the flip side of that, social media has the potential to positive impact relationships through the information that we take in. In my journey to optimize my health with a 360 strategy, mind, body, and soul, I've follows professionals who provide actionable insights into my wellness (all back by credible research, of course.) this knowledge has not only benefited me personally but also professionally. As a co-chair for a business resource group focused on wellness in the workplace, I've been able to incorporate a lot of practices and things that I have found thanks to my social media network. Sharing evidence-based strategies for mental and physical health has fostered a sense of community among colleagues, encouraging meaningful connecting and improving workplace culture. Helping them combat, fatigue,

burn out and maximize their human potential in both life and work. After all, we are who we are, at work and at home.

Personal biases play a significant role in how individuals consume information on social media. Research conducted by the Observatory on social media at Indiana University identifies three key types of biases: biases in the brain, society, and machines. Cognitive biases, for example, arise from the way the brain processes daily information. One such bias involved emotional responses to headlines. Studies show that people often judge the credibility of an articulate based on its headlines emotional appeal rather than its actual content (Ciampaglia et al., 2018). This susceptibility can make individuals more likely to engage with misinformation or disregard credible information that conflicts with their beliefs.

A 2018 study by the Pew Research center found that 64% of U.S. adults believed that fabricated news stories cause a great deal of confusion about basic facts in current events. This highlights the extent to which personal biases, combined with widespread misinformation, can influence public perception and decision making. Such tendencies can strengthen echo chambers, where individuals are primarily exposed to information that aligns with their preexisting views, further enhancing their biases (Rainie et al., 2022).

Acknowledging personal biases is crucial in mitigating their effects. When individuals recognize their tendencies to favor information that aligns with their worldview, they can take steps to evaluate sources critically (Ciampaglia et al., 2018).. This self-awareness helps create a more balanced perspective, fostering healthier personal and professional relationships. For example, being aware of biases can prevent unnecessary conflicts arising from misinterpreted or emotionally charged social media content. We are so quick to share or repost something that as mentioned earlier in the article, evokes an emotional response. Being aware of this could help us show up more authentically in our communities on social media where we are so closely connected with our friends and family.

Acknowledging personal biases doesn't just improve how we gather information; it has the potential to strengthen our relationships. When people try to understand how their biases influence their interactions, they can approach conversations with empathy and open-mindedness. This is particularly important in professional settings, where diverse viewpoints often exist. Recognizing that everyone has biases allows for more meaningful and constructive dialog, which could reduce the risk of misunderstandings and foster more collaboration.

Social media platforms have had both positive and negative effects on relationships in society. On the post side, these platforms enable people to stay connected, share ideas, and find support networks. For instancing, during the lock downs during the pandemic, social media served as a lifeline for many, enabling them to maintain relationships and socialize despite the physical isolation. However, the

negative impacts cannot be ignored. Misinformation, echo chambers, cyberbullying, have all contributed to social divides and strained relationships. The algorithms designed to keep users engaged often amplify biases, creating environments where opposing views are rarely encountered. This polarization can erode trust and hinder meaningful connections.

Social media is a powerful tool that can enhance or undermine relationships depending on how it is used. By acknowledging personal biases and critically evaluating information, individuals can navigate the challenges of misinformation and build strong personal and professional connections. While social media has its flaws, its potential to foster meaningful relationships and promote positive change remains undeniable when approached thoughtfully.

To truly harness this potential, we as users must actively take responsibility for our digital behavior, seeking out credible sources, questioning the motives behind shared content and broadening our perspectives by engaging with diverse viewpoints. This intentional approach has the potential to not only strengthen relationships but also nurtures healthier online communities where trust and understanding can thrive.

As society becomes increasingly reliant on digital platforms, the responsibility to use these tools effectively lies with each of us. By balancing the benefits and dark side of social media, we can leverage its power to enrich our lives, build stronger connections, and contribute to a more informed and united world.

Reference

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